in various parts of Pakistan. On the other hand, Afghan president Babrak Karmal was persuaded by the Soviet leadership and the KGB sometime in mid-1986 to step down and hand the presidency to Dr Najibullah, the Afghan intelligence chief.

The CIA observed that Rajiv Gandhi's government felt that the regional repercussions of the Soviet invasion posed a direct threat to India since it had introduced increased superpower competition to a region where India aspired to be an unchallenged military and political power.

The American assessment was true to a certain extent, believed several R&AW officials who spoke to me. They argued that as the Indian government was getting increasingly involved in Sri Lanka, they did not want another vulnerable front on the Pakistani side.

A declassified CIA report dated 9 October 1987 noted that Rajiv Gandhi felt the Afghan issue was an irritant in India's relations with the Soviets and the USA, but he did not believe India could do anything to significantly influence the outcome of the Afghan conflict. A CIA report said:

He (Rajiv Gandhi) is likely to be receptive to US agreements that India encourage a role for former Afghan King Zahir Shah or non-sectarian political parties in an interim and post-settlement government. Gandhi is also interested in limiting Islamabad influence in a post-withdrawal Afghanistan so that a Pakistani-backed Islamic fundamentalist regime in Kabul does not cause problems for India. His concern is that India's 90 million Muslims could be more susceptible to the influence of an Islamic-ruled Iran, Afghanistan and Pakistan after what